

Your grammar companion

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The jobs words do

Start with the job a word does in this sentence. The same word can do different jobs: **I work** (verb); **my work** (noun).

Noun

Names a person, place, thing, or idea. Can be a subject or object.

The **student** reads a **book**.

Verb

Shows an action or state. Usually follows the subject in statements.

They **study**. She **is** tired. I **know**.

Adjective

Describes a noun or pronoun; often before a noun or after be / look / feel / seem.

a **quiet** room; The room is **quiet**.

Preposition

Shows a relationship in time, place, or direction. Follow with a noun, pronoun, or -ing form.

at work; **with** him; **before** leaving

Pronoun

Replaces a noun. Use subject forms before the verb; object forms after a verb or preposition.

She called **him**. This is for **us**.

Article

A / an introduces one countable thing. The identifies a specific one.

I need **a** pen. Please pass **the** blue pen.

Adverb

Describes a verb, adjective, adverb, or a whole sentence. Position depends on its job.

She speaks **clearly**. It is **very** cold.

Conjunction

Connects words, phrases, or clauses. FANBOYS: for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so.

tea **or** coffee; I was tired, **but** I finished.

See each word's job

The helpful nurse speaks clearly, and she listens to patients.

ART ADJ N V ADV CONJ PRON V PREP N

Commands The subject you is understood: **Open your book.** / **Do not run.**

Build a Sentence

A complete statement needs a **SUBJECT** and a **VERB**.

Start with WHO + VERB. Add the information your idea needs.

1	WHO / SUBJECT I	VERB work.			
2	WHO / SUBJECT I	VERB study	WHAT / OBJECT English.		
3	WHO / SUBJECT I	VERB study	WHAT / OBJECT English	WHERE at school.	
4	WHO / SUBJECT I	VERB study	WHAT / OBJECT English	WHERE at school	WHEN on Tuesdays.

WHERE or WHEN can come first

WHERE At school,	WHO I	VERB study	WHAT English.	
WHEN On Tuesdays,	WHO I	VERB study	WHAT English	WHERE at school.

Same idea, different focus. In a statement, keep WHO before the verb.

Sometimes the verb needs a helper

WHO She	HELPER + NOT doesn't	VERB work	WHEN on Fridays.
WHO They	HELPER are	VERB studying	WHAT English.
WHO I	HELPER will	VERB call	WHEN tomorrow.

All of these are complete

I work.

I work nights.

I work at a restaurant.

I work nights at a restaurant.

You do not need every piece. **Add only what your idea needs.**

Pronouns, articles & sentence basics

Subject	Object	Before a noun	On its own
I	me	my book	mine
you	you	your book	yours
he	him	his book	his
she	her	her book	hers
it	it	its cover	—
we	us	our books	ours
they	them	their books	theirs

My / your / his / her / its / our / their are possessive determiners before nouns. Compare: **This is my book. This book is mine.**

A, an, the, or no article?

a / an

One singular countable thing, not a specific one. Choose a / an by sound.

a job; **an** apple; **an** hour; **a** university

1

the

The listener knows which one; a specific item or group.

The appointment we discussed is today.

2

no article

General plural or uncountable nouns.

Books help us learn. Water is important.

3

Build a complete statement

Subject + verb + the rest of the idea.

She works at the hospital. / He is a driver. / They feel happy.

Remember be English needs a verb: **She is tired**, not “She tired.” Use an article for a singular job: **He is a nurse**.

Its / it's **Its** shows possession: its cover. **It's** means it is or it has: It's raining.

Adjectives, adverbs & frequency

Adjectives

Describe: Nouns and pronouns

Questions: What kind? Which one? How many?

Examples: a **red** car; **three** books; You look **happy**.

Adverbs

Describe: Verbs, adjectives, other adverbs, whole sentences

Questions: How? When? Where? How often? To what extent?

Examples: She drives **carefully**. It is **very** cold. **Luckily**, we arrived.

Not always -ly Good → well: She is a **good** driver. She drives **well**. Fast → fast; hard → hard. **Hardly** means almost not, not “with effort.”

How often?

always	I always bring my binder.
usually / normally	I usually take the bus. I normally arrive early.
often	We often study together.
sometimes	I sometimes work on Saturdays.
occasionally	We occasionally meet after class.
seldom / rarely	She rarely misses class.
hardly ever	He hardly ever watches TV.
never	I never leave without my keys.

These words show a general frequency, not exact percentages. **Always** is every time; **never** is no time.

Word order Before most main verbs: **I usually walk**. After be: **I am usually early**. After the first helping verb: **I have never been there**. Sometimes can also begin or end a sentence.

Prepositions of time

Choose the preposition for the time expression, not the verb tense.



a larger period

in April
in summer / the summer
in 2027
in the 1990s
in the 21st century
in the past / future
in the morning
in the afternoon
in the evening



a day or date

on Monday
on June 15
on my birthday
on test day
on our anniversary
on the weekend (US)
on Monday morning
on Friday evening
on Saturday night



a point

at 4 o'clock
at 10:30 p.m.
at noon / midnight
at breakfast
at lunchtime
at dinnertime
at night
at the moment
at present

Other useful time relationships

Expression	Meaning	Example
for + duration	How long	for two hours; for five years
since + starting point	When a continuing period began	since Monday; since 2020
by + deadline	No later than	Please call by 5:00.
until + endpoint	Continues up to that time	I work until 5:00.
during + noun	Within a period or event	during class; during the meeting
before / after	Earlier / later	before lunch; after work

No at / in / on Use **next week, last Monday, this morning, every day**: "I work every Saturday," not "on every Saturday."

Look closely **At night**, but **on Friday night**. **In two hours** can mean two hours from now. For tense choices, see Perfect tenses (p. 15).

Prepositions of Place

Find the relationship. The dot is the object; the box is its landmark. Read each picture as a tiny scene.

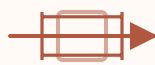
		
in	on	under
		
above	below	in front of
		
behind	next to	between
		
on the left	on the right	opposite

Compare the meanings On means touching a surface; above means higher, with no contact required. Under and below both mean lower; under often means directly beneath. Between identifies a position among distinct things.

The keys are **in** the bag. The bag is **under** the chair. The chair is **next to** the table.

Prepositions of Movement

Follow the arrow. Its starting point, path, and endpoint tell the story of the movement.

01  into the box	02  out of the box	03  around the box	04  away from the box
05  toward the box	06  past the box	07  onto the box	08  off the box
09  over the box	10  under the wall	11  through the pipe	12  across the bridge
13  up the stairs	14  down the stairs		

Compare the meanings In / on describe a position. Into / onto show movement to that position. Across goes from one side to the other; through goes inside a space and out. Toward gives direction, without saying you arrive.

Walk **across** the street, go **through** the door, and walk **up** the stairs.

The five verb forms

The formulas use short labels for verb forms. These labels name the shape of a verb, not a complete tense.

V1	Base Form (V1) walk go / eat	01
V1-s	He / She / It Form (V1-s) walks goes / eats	02
V-ing	-ing Form (V-ing) walking going / eating	03
V2	Past Form (V2) walked went / ate	04
V3	Past Participle (V3) walked gone / eaten	05

Match the subject and helper

Subject	Present be	Past be	Present helpers
I	am	was	have / do
he / she / it	is	was	has / does
you / we / they	are	were	have / do

Spelling patterns

-s / -es: work → works; watch → watches; study → studies.

-ing: work → working; make → making; run → running; lie → lying.

-ed: work → worked; live → lived; study → studied; stop → stopped.

One helper changes the next verb After **do / does / did** and modals such as **will**, use V1. After perfect **have / has / had**, use V3. Continuous forms need **be + V-ing**.

Reading the charts “Subject” means I, she, the students, etc. Choose one form from a slash list: am / is / are. The next chart (p. 11) shows all three sentence forms.

How irregular verbs work

Regular verbs add **-ed** for V2 and V3. Irregular verbs have their own patterns. Learn the three forms together.

Base Form (V1)	Past Form (V2)	Past Participle (V3)	Pattern
put	put	put	All three match
buy	bought	bought	V2 and V3 match
come	came	come	V1 and V3 match
go	went	gone	Three different forms
take	took	taken	Three different forms
read	read	read	Same spelling; different sound

Choose the form for your sentence

Past: She went to work. → Use V2.

Perfect: She has gone to work. → After have / has / had, use V3.

After did, return to V1 Did she go? / She did not go. Not “Did she went?”

Read: listen for the difference V1 read sounds like “reed.” V2 and V3 read sound like “red.”

Get → **got** → **gotten / got**. Gotten is common in US English for become or obtain; got is common in British English.

Need another verb? See your Verb Reference.

12 tenses: formula chart

REFERENCE, NOT MEMORIZATION . Use this chart when you know the tense and need the pattern.

V1 = Base Form • V1-s = He / She / It Form • V-ing = -ing Form • V2 = Past Form • V3 = Past Participle. See verb forms (p. 9).

Subject **Helping verb** **Main verb** **Negative**

Tense	Affirmative	Negative	Question
Present Simple	subject + V1 / V1-s	subject + do(es) + not + V1	Do(es) + subject + V1?
Past Simple	subject + V2	subject + did + not + V1	Did + subject + V1?
Future Simple	subject + will + V1	subject + will + not + V1	Will + subject + V1?
Present Continuous	subject + am/is/are + V-ing	subject + am/is/are + not + V-ing	Am/Is/Are + subject + V-ing?
Past Continuous	subject + was/were + V-ing	subject + was/were + not + V-ing	Was/Were + subject + V-ing?
Future Continuous	subject + will be + V-ing	subject + will not be + V-ing	Will + subject + be + V-ing?
Present Perfect	subject + have/has + V3	subject + have/has + not + V3	Have/Has + subject + V3?
Past Perfect	subject + had + V3	subject + had + not + V3	Had + subject + V3?
Future Perfect	subject + will + have + V3	subject + will + not + have + V3	Will + subject + have + V3?
Present Perfect Continuous	subject + have/has + been + V-ing	subject + have/has + not + been + V-ing	Have/Has + subject + been + V-ing?
Past Perfect Continuous	subject + had + been + V-ing	subject + had + not + been + V-ing	Had + subject + been + V-ing?
Future Perfect Continuous	subject + will have been + V-ing	subject + will not have been + V-ing	Will + subject + have been + V-ing?

Simple be is different Present: I am / she is / they are. Past: I / she was; you / they were. Add not for negatives; move be before the subject for questions. Do not add do / did.

12 tenses: one verb, every pattern

walk → walks → walking → walked → walked. Follow the same subject and verb across all twelve patterns. Full forms make the helpers easier to see.

Subject Helping verb Main verb Negative

Tense	Affirmative	Negative	Question
Present Simple	She walks.	She does not walk.	Does she walk?
Past Simple	She walked.	She did not walk.	Did she walk?
Future Simple	She will walk.	She will not walk.	Will she walk?
Present Continuous	She is walking.	She is not walking.	Is she walking?
Past Continuous	She was walking.	She was not walking.	Was she walking?
Future Continuous	She will be walking.	She will not be walking.	Will she be walking?
Present Perfect	She has walked.	She has not walked.	Has she walked?
Past Perfect	She had walked.	She had not walked.	Had she walked?
Future Perfect	She will have walked.	She will not have walked.	Will she have walked?
Present Perfect Continuous	She has been walking.	She has not been walking.	Has she been walking?
Past Perfect Continuous	She had been walking.	She had not been walking.	Had she been walking?
Future Perfect Continuous	She will have been walking.	She will not have been walking.	Will she have been walking?

Notice the helper She walks → Does she walk? She walked → Did she walk? In longer verb phrases, move only the first helper to begin the question.

Simple Tenses

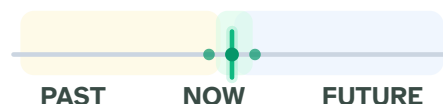
Say what happens, happened, or will happen.

Routines & facts • finished past • predictions & decisions

PRESENT SIMPLE

She takes the bus every morning.

Habits, routines, facts, and states. Add -s / -es for he, she, it in affirmative statements.



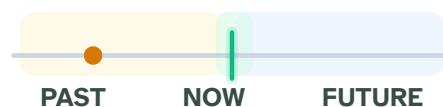
Time clues every day, usually, often, sometimes, never

Remember She works, but she does not work. Does she work? After does, use V1. For be, use am / is / are without do.

PAST SIMPLE

I cooked dinner last night.

Completed actions or states in a finished past time. Regular verbs use -ed; irregular verbs have a special V2.



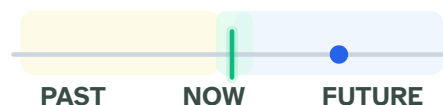
Time clues yesterday, last week, two days ago, in 2020

Remember She went, but she did not go. Did she go? After did, use V1. Be uses was / were without did.

FUTURE SIMPLE

We will visit the library tomorrow.

Predictions, promises, offers, and decisions made as we speak.



Time clues tomorrow, next week, soon, later

Remember Use be going to + V1 for an existing plan or a prediction based on evidence. I will help you. / I am going to start a course.

Build negatives & questions: formulas (p. 11) • examples (p. 12).

Read timelines left to right: past → now → future. Dots = events; lines = activity; arcs = connections.

Continuous Tenses

Picture an action in progress.

At that moment, the action is happening.

PRESENT CONTINUOUS

I am washing the dishes right now.

An action happening now or around now; a temporary situation.
Also a future arrangement with a time expression.



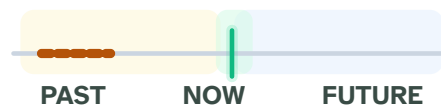
Time clues now, right now, at the moment, this week

Remember I am studying this month. / I am meeting my teacher tomorrow. State verbs such as know, need, and believe usually use simple forms.

PAST CONTINUOUS

I was cooking when the phone rang.

An action in progress at a past time. Often gives background for a shorter past action.



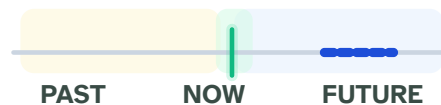
Time clues at 8 last night, while, when

Remember I was cooking when the phone rang. Cooking was in progress; the call happened during it. Two ongoing actions can both use past continuous.

FUTURE CONTINUOUS

I will be working at 8 tomorrow.

An action that will be in progress at a particular future time.



Time clues this time tomorrow, at 8 tomorrow, when you arrive

Remember At 8 tomorrow, I will be working. This describes the activity in progress, not its completion.

Build negatives & questions: formulas (p. 11) · examples (p. 12).

Read timelines left to right: past → now → future. Dots = events; lines = activity; arcs = connections.

Perfect Tenses

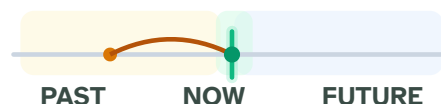
Look back from a point in time.

Connect an earlier action or situation to now, then, or a future point.

PRESENT PERFECT

I have finished my homework already.

Past experience, a present result, or a situation that began in the past and continues now.



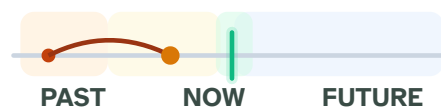
Time clues ever, never, already, yet, just, since, for

Remember I have lost my keys (I cannot find them now). I lost them yesterday (finished past time). Do not pair present perfect with a finished time such as yesterday.

PAST PERFECT

She had left before the meeting started.

An action finished before another past action or time.



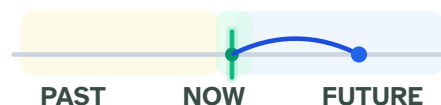
Time clues already, before, by the time

Remember When I arrived, class had started. Class started first. Do not use past perfect simply because an event happened long ago.

FUTURE PERFECT

She will have finished the report by noon.

An action that will be finished by a future time or deadline.



Time clues by Friday, by then, by the time

Remember By Friday, I will have finished the report. After by the time in a future time clause, use present simple: by the time you arrive.

Build negatives & questions: formulas (p. 11) · examples (p. 12).

Read timelines left to right: past → now → future. Dots = events; lines = activity; arcs = connections.

Perfect Continuous Tenses

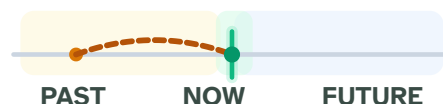
Focus on how long the activity continues.

Follow an activity up to now, a past point, or a future point.

PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS

I have been living here for two years.

An activity continuing from the past to now, or recently stopped with a present result. Emphasizes activity or duration.



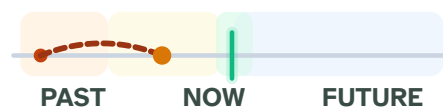
Time clues for, since, all morning, lately

Remember I have been studying for two hours. I have studied three chapters emphasizes a completed amount. Use I have known her, not have been knowing.

PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS

They had been playing for hours before dinner.

An activity continuing up to a past time. It may explain a past result.



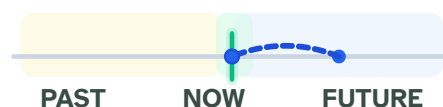
Time clues for, since, before, when, by the time

Remember I was tired because I had been working all day. The work happened before that past feeling.

FUTURE PERFECT CONTINUOUS

By June, I will have been working here for a year.

How long an activity will have continued by a future time.



Time clues for + duration, by then, by the time

Remember By June, I will have been studying here for a year. The emphasis is how long; the activity may continue.

Build negatives & questions: formulas (p. 11) · examples (p. 12).

Read timelines left to right: past → now → future. Dots = events; lines = activity; arcs = connections.

Choose the meaning before the tense

1 Routine / now

A I work at a clinic.

B I am working late today.

Usual situation / temporary activity

2 Finished past / connection to now

A I lost my keys yesterday.

B I have lost my keys.

Finished time / present result

3 Amount / duration

A I have read three chapters.

B I have been reading for two hours.

Completed amount / activity and duration

4 Future decision / plan / arrangement

A I will help you.

B I am going to study tonight.

C I am meeting Ana at six.

Decision now / existing intention / arrangement

Be in the simple tenses

Time	Affirmative	Negative	Question
Present	She is ready.	She is not ready.	Is she ready?
Past	They were late.	They were not late.	Were they late?
Future	He will be here.	He will not be here.	Will he be here?

State verbs Know, believe, need, and own usually take simple forms. Some verbs change meaning: **I think it is useful** (opinion); **I am thinking about it** (mental activity).

Time words are clues, not guarantees For and since can occur with different tenses. Ask which reference point you mean: now, a past point, or a future point. Read the entire sentence.

Build a question & answer it

MOVE THE HELPER			
STATEMENT	SUBJECT She	HELPER is	REST ready.
QUESTION	HELPER Is	SUBJECT she	REST ready?

Find the helping verb first. In a yes / no question, it moves before the subject. If a simple tense has no helping verb, add do / does / did.

Statement	Yes / no question	Short answer
She is ready.	Is she ready?	Yes, she is . / No, she isn't .
They work here.	Do they work here?	Yes, they do . / No, they don't .
He works today.	Does he work today?	Yes, he does . / No, he doesn't .
You called.	Did you call?	Yes, I did . / No, I didn't .
She has left.	Has she left?	Yes, she has . / No, she hasn't .
They will come.	Will they come?	Yes, they will . / No, they won't .
He can drive.	Can he drive?	Yes, he can . / No, he can't .

Add a question word for more information

Where does she work? → At the clinic.

When did you call? → Yesterday.

Why are they waiting? → The office is closed.

How long have you lived here? → For three years.

Asking about the subject Who called you? Who is the subject; do not add did in an ordinary affirmative subject question. Compare **Who did you call?** You is the subject; who asks about the object.

Match the helper Answer with the same helper: **Have you finished? Yes, I have.** Change the pronoun as needed: Are you ready? → Yes, I am.

Two actions: background & order

A sentence can connect two actions. Decide whether one action was in progress, one happened earlier, or both continued together.

Relationship	Tense pairing	Example
An action during another	past continuous + past simple	I was studying when the power went out.
Two ongoing actions	past continuous + past continuous	While I was cooking , he was washing the dishes.
An earlier completed action	past perfect + past simple	She had left before I arrived .
Duration before a past event	past perfect continuous + past simple	They had been waiting for an hour when the bus came .

Read the order, not just the order of words



When I arrived, she had left.

First: she left. Then: I arrived.

She had left when I arrived describes the same order.

When / while **While** often introduces an ongoing action. **When** can introduce a point in time. Neither word automatically chooses the tense; the meaning does.

An interruption is only one possibility An earlier completed event is not an interruption. Avoid a blanket rule such as “drop one tense back.”

See Continuous tenses (p. 14) and Perfect tenses (p. 15).

Future time clauses

After **when, before, after, until, as soon as**, and **by the time**, use a present form for a future time clause.

Main idea	Time clause	Complete example
will + V1	when + present simple	I will call when I arrive .
will be + V-ing	when + present simple	I will be working when you arrive .
will have + V3	by the time + present simple	We will have finished by the time the guests arrive .
will have been + V-ing	when + present simple	When June comes , I will have been studying here for a year.

Choose the meaning

START I will cook when you arrive . Cooking will start then.	IN PROGRESS I will be cooking when you arrive . Cooking will be in progress.	FINISHED I will have cooked by the time you arrive . Cooking will be finished.
---	---	---

Present perfect is also possible Use it to emphasize completion: **I will call after I have finished work.** Present simple is also possible: **after I finish work.**

Time clause or question? **I will call when she arrives** is a time clause. **I do not know when she will arrive** is an indirect question, so will is possible.

Comma guide

Time clause first: **When I arrive, I will call.**

Main clause first: **I will call when I arrive.**

For if clauses, see Conditionals (p. 22).

Connect your ideas

Choose the connection you want to make.

ADD

More information

and • also • in addition

I work at a clinic, **and** I study at night.

CONTRAST

A different or surprising idea

but • however • although

Although I was tired, I finished my shift.

REASON

Why something happens

because • since

I called **because** I needed an appointment.

RESULT

What happens because of it

so • therefore

The bus was late, **so** I called my supervisor.

EXAMPLE

Make the idea specific

for example • such as

Bring identification, **such as** a passport.

ORDER

Steps in a sequence

first • then • next • finally

First, fill out the form. **Then**, sign it.

TIME

Connect actions in time

before • after • when • while

After I finish work, I pick up my son.

Punctuation that helps your reader

Two complete ideas + and / but / so: use a comma before the connector.

I called, **but** no one answered.

However / therefore / in addition / for example: a new sentence is an easy choice. Put a comma after the opening connector.

The office was closed. **However**, I could leave a message.

Keep the connection complete **Because / since / although + subject + verb** needs a main clause. If it comes first, follow it with a comma: **Because I was sick, I stayed home.** Use **such as + noun examples**, not a new sentence.

Conditionals: condition & result

The if clause gives a condition. The main clause gives its result. Choose the pattern for the meaning, not only the time word.

0

Zero: general truth or routine

CONDITION
if + present simple



RESULT
present simple

If I work late, I take the bus.

1

First: real future possibility

CONDITION
if + present simple



RESULT
will + V1

If it rains tomorrow, I will stay home.

2

Second: imagined now or future

CONDITION
if + past simple



RESULT
would + V1

If I had more time, I would cook more.

3

Third: imagined past

CONDITION
if + past perfect



RESULT
would have + V3

If I had known, I would have helped.

Change the clause order, keep the meaning

If it rains, I will stay home. / I will stay home if it rains.

Use a comma when the if clause comes first.

Meaning matters The second conditional uses a past form for an imagined present or future: **If I had a car, I would drive.** It does not necessarily describe past time.

Useful variations **If I were you, I would ask.** Could and might can replace would when the meaning is ability or possibility. A first-conditional result can give advice or a command: **If you need help, ask.**

Avoid the common mix-up For the usual first conditional, use **If it rains**, not "If it will rain." For the third, use **would have + V3**, not "would + present perfect."

Contractions

An apostrophe shows missing letters. Contractions are common in speaking and informal writing.

Subject + helper

I am	→ I'm
you / we / they are	→ you're / we're / they're
he / she / it is	→ he's / she's / it's
I / you / we / they have	→ I've / you've / we've / they've
he / she / it has	→ he's / she's / it's
I / you / he / she will	→ I'll / you'll / he'll / she'll
it / we / they will	→ it'll / we'll / they'll
I / you / he / she had or would	→ I'd / you'd / he'd / she'd
it / we / they had or would	→ it'd / we'd / they'd

Negative & other forms

is / are not	→ isn't / aren't
was / were not	→ wasn't / weren't
have / has / had not	→ haven't / hasn't / hadn't
do / does / did not	→ don't / doesn't / didn't
will / would not	→ won't / wouldn't
cannot / could not	→ can't / couldn't
should / must not	→ shouldn't / mustn't
need not	→ needn't
let us	→ let's

Use the next word to understand 's and 'd

She's working. → She **is** working.

She's finished her work. → She **has** finished her work.

She'd left before noon. → She **had** left before noon.

She'd help if she could. → She **would** help if she could.

Short answers Say **Yes, I am**, not "Yes, I'm." Negative short answers can contract: **No, I'm not. No, she hasn't.**

Look-alikes **You're** = you are; **your** = belonging to you. **They're** = they are; **their** = belonging to them; **there** = a place.

Modals: meaning & form

Core modals use **modal + V1**: she can drive, not “can drives” or “can to drive.” Negatives add not; questions put the modal first.

can

Ability; permission; requests

“I **can** swim. **Can** I sit here?”

may

Possibility; formal permission

“It **may** rain. **May** I come in?”

must

Strong obligation; strong deduction

“You **must** sign here. She **must** be tired.”

will

Predictions; promises; decisions

“I **will** call you tonight.”

shall

Offers or suggestions, especially with I / we

“**Shall** we begin?”

could

Past general ability; possibility; polite requests

“I **could** swim at six. **Could** you help?”

might

Possibility

“The bus **might** be late.”

should / ought to

Advice; expectation

“You **should** rest. The bus **ought to** arrive soon.”

would

Polite requests; imagined results; past habits

“**Would** you help? I **would** go if I **could**.”

Related expressions have their own grammar

Expression	Pattern	Example
have to / need to	Change with subject and tense; use do in simple questions.	She has to go. Did you have to wait?
be supposed to	Change be; expected arrangement or duty.	We are supposed to meet here.
had better	had better + V1; strong advice about now or later.	You had better leave. You had better not wait.

Keep the meanings separate **Must not** = prohibited. **Do not have to** = not necessary; you may choose.

Possibility, advice & requirements

How sure is the speaker?



Possible

may / might / could

She **might** be at work.



Expected

should / ought to

She **should** be home by now.



Strong deduction

must

Her car is here. She **must** be home.



Strong negative deduction

can't / couldn't

That **can't** be her car; hers is blue.

These express a speaker's judgment, not fixed percentages. The same modal can have a different meaning in a different context.

What does someone need to do?

YES

Permission

can / may

You **may** use this room.

TRY

Advice

should / ought to

You **should** bring your notes.

DO

Requirement

must / have to / need to

You **have to** bring identification.

STOP

Prohibition

must not / can't

You **must not** park here.

CHOICE

No requirement

don't have to / don't need to

You **don't have to** arrive early.

Listen for the difference

He must work today. → A requirement.

He must be at work. → A deduction from evidence.

He can work here. → Permission or ability, depending on context.

Healthcare and workplace language The appointment **may change** expresses possibility. **You should ask a question** gives advice. **Visitors must sign in** states a requirement. These are different meanings, not points on one scale.

Modals and the past

Meaning	Past form	Example
General past ability	could + V1	When I was young, I could run fast.
Success on one occasion	was / were able to; managed to	Yesterday, I was able to fix the printer.
Past necessity	had to + V1	I had to leave early.
No past necessity	didn't have to + V1	I didn't have to work yesterday.
Past expectation	was / were supposed to + V1	We were supposed to meet at noon.
Possible past event	may / might / could have + V3	She might have missed the bus.
Strong past deduction	must have + V3	He must have forgotten the appointment.
Impossible past explanation	can't / couldn't have + V3	She can't have sent it; her phone was off.
Past advice or regret	should / ought to have + V3	I should have called earlier.
Imagined past result	would have + V3	I would have helped if I had known .

Must have ≠ **had to** She **must have left** is a deduction. She **had to leave** was a requirement.

Could have has more than one meaning She **could have taken the bus** can mean it was possible, or it was an available option she did not take. Context tells you which.

LOOK BACK

modal + have + V3

A possibility, deduction, regret, or imagined result about the past.

Past habits with would

When we were children, we would play outside every evening. Use **would** for repeated actions in an established past context. For past states, use **used to**: I **used to** live nearby.

See **Used to / be used to / get used to** (p. 30) and **Conditionals** (p. 22).

Gerunds & infinitives: patterns

-ing

The gerund path

Gerund as subject

Swimming is fun.

The whole -ing phrase acts as a noun.

Preposition + gerund

She thought about **calling**.

Also: after eating; without asking.

Verb + gerund

He enjoys **learning**.

Learn which pattern follows the first verb.

to + V1

The infinitive path

Adjective + infinitive

It is nice **to meet** you.

Also: ready to go; happy to help.

Verb + infinitive

We want **to visit** Mexico.

to + base verb, not to + past verb.

Verb + object + infinitive

She asked **me to call**.

The object tells us who will call.

Noun + infinitive

I have time **to study**.

The infinitive gives more information.

Infinitive of purpose

I went out **to buy** milk.

Answers "Why?"

When to is a preposition

I look forward to meeting you.

She is used to driving here.

These expressions take a noun or -ing form after to. Compare: **She wants to drive.**

Some verbs change meaning

Verb	Gerund	Infinitive
stop	He stopped smoking . = quit the habit	He stopped to smoke . = paused another activity
remember	I remember locking it. = memory of an action	Remember to lock it. = do not forget the task
try	Try taking the bus. = test a possible solution	Try to arrive early. = make an effort

Not a tense by itself An -ing form can be a noun-like gerund (**Swimming is fun**) or part of a continuous verb (**She is swimming**).

Which form follows this verb?

REFERENCE, NOT MEMORIZATION

Find the first verb, then choose the form that follows it.

-ING

Follow with -ing

admit
advise
appreciate
avoid
complete
consider
deny
discuss
dislike
enjoy
finish
imagine
keep
mention
mind
miss
practice
quit
recommend
suggest

TO + V1

Follow with to + V1

afford
agree
appear
ask
decide
expect
hope
intend
learn
mean
need
offer
plan
prepare
promise
refuse
seem
volunteer
wait
want

EITHER

Either in common uses

begin
continue
hate
like
love
prefer
start

I love **singing**.

I love **to sing**.

Meaning can vary with context.

Objects change some patterns I advise leaving early. / I advise you to leave early. Also: ask someone to help; want someone to call. Do not add an object to every verb: say I hope to go or I hope you can go.

Suggest / recommend I suggest taking the bus. / I suggest that you take the bus. Avoid “I suggest you to take.”

Comparatives & superlatives

Compare two things with a comparative. Identify the highest or lowest in a group with a superlative.

Adjective pattern	Comparative	Superlative
Most one-syllable: tall	taller than	the tallest
Ends in -e: nice	nicer than	the nicest
Short vowel + final consonant: big	bigger than	the biggest
Consonant + -y: happy	happier than	the happiest
Longer adjectives: expensive	more expensive than	the most expensive
Less of a quality	less expensive than	the least expensive
good	better than	the best
bad	worse than	the worst
far	farther / further than	the farthest / furthest



Useful sentence patterns

This route is **faster than** that one.

This is the **fastest** route in the city.

My bag is **as heavy as** yours. (equal)

This room is **not as large as** that one. (not equal)

Do not double the comparison Say **easier**, not “more easier”; **the best**, not “the most best.” Some two-syllable adjectives allow both patterns: **cleverer / more clever**.

Compare actions too She drives **more carefully than** I do. He runs **faster than** me. She speaks English **better** now.

Used to / be used to / get used to

THEN, NOT NOW

used to

A past habit or state that is no longer true

used to + V1
I **used to** live nearby.

FAMILIAR NOW

be used to

Familiar or accustomed to something

be + **used to** + noun / -ing
I **am used to** working nights.

BECOMING FAMILIAR

get used to

Become familiar or accustomed over time

get + **used to** + noun / -ing
I **am getting used to** my schedule.

Affirmative, negative & question

Expression	Affirmative	Negative	Question
used to	She used to drive .	She didn't use to drive .	Did she use to drive?
be used to	She is used to driving .	She isn't used to driving .	Is she used to driving?
get used to	She got used to driving .	She didn't get used to driving .	Did she get used to driving?

Change be or get to change the time

I was used to the noise. → familiar in the past.

I will get used to the noise. → becoming familiar in the future.

I have gotten used to it. → the change has happened (US English).

Two different kinds of to Past habit: **used to + V1**. Familiarity: **be / get used to + noun or -ing**. The three expressions are not stages on one percentage scale.

Did removes the -d Use **didn't use to** and **Did you use to...?** Compare a current habit: **I usually walk**, not "I use to walk."

Passive voice: change the focus

ACTIVE	DOER Maria	ACTION read	RECEIVER the book.
--------	----------------------	-----------------------	------------------------------

The subject does the action. Move the spotlight to the receiver:

PASSIVE	RECEIVER The book	BE + V3 was read	BY + DOER by Maria.
---------	-----------------------------	----------------------------	-------------------------------

The subject receives the action.

Tense	Passive formula	Active → passive
Present simple	am / is / are + V3	The teacher checks it. → It is checked .
Past simple	was / were + V3	They repaired it. → It was repaired .
Present continuous	am / is / are + being + V3	They are moving it. → It is being moved .
Past continuous	was / were + being + V3	They were moving it. → It was being moved .
Present perfect	have / has + been + V3	They have finished it. → It has been finished .
Past perfect	had + been + V3	They had found it. → It had been found .
Future simple	will + be + V3	They will deliver it. → It will be delivered .
Modal	modal + be + V3	They should clean it. → It should be cleaned .

When is passive useful?

The doer is unknown: **My bike was stolen.**

The result matters: **The bridge was repaired.**

The doer is obvious: **He was arrested.**

A formal or less direct statement: **A mistake was made.**

Build it carefully The old object becomes the new subject. Match be to the new subject: **The rooms are cleaned.** Keep V3. Add **by + doer** only when useful.

Questions and negatives **Was it delivered? / It was not delivered.** Change the first helping verb. Verbs without an object, such as arrive, do not normally form a passive.

Reported speech: tell what someone said

Direct speech gives exact words. Reported speech gives the message. Adjust pronouns to show who is speaking and who is being discussed.

Common shift after said / told	Direct speech	Reported speech
present → past	"I work here."	She said she worked there.
present continuous → past continuous	"I am studying ."	She said she was studying .
past → past perfect	"I moved in 2020."	He said he had moved in 2020.
present perfect → past perfect	"I have finished ."	He said he had finished .
will → would	"I will call ."	She said she would call .
can → could	"I can help ."	She said she could help .
past perfect → past perfect	"I had already left ."	He said he had already left .

HER WORDS

"I **am** tired."

YOUR REPORT

She said she **was** tired.

Said or told?

She said (that) she was tired.

She told me (that) she was tired.

Use an object with told: told me / told us. Say **said to me**, not "said me."

Backshift is not automatic When reporting later with a past reporting verb, a tense shift is common. If the fact is still true, keeping the original tense can be appropriate: **She said she lives in Boston.** With says, often keep the tense: **She says she is tired.**

Keep the speaker's meaning Do not change names, dates, or facts mechanically. "I graduated in 1975" still refers to 1975 when reported.

Continue with Time, place & reported questions (p. 33).

Time, place & reported questions

Change these expressions when the reporting time or location has changed. If you are still in the same place or day, the original word may still fit.

today / yesterday → **that day / the day before**

She said she had called **the day before**.

tomorrow → **the next / following day**

He said he would call **the next day**.

this week → **that week**

She said she was busy **that week**.

last month → **the month before**

They said they had moved **the month before**.

next year → **the following year**

He said he would graduate **the following year**.

here → **there**

She said she had grown up **there**.

this / these → **that / those**

He said **those** photos were his.

Report a question with statement word order

Question type	Direct	Reported
Yes / no: if or whether	"Do you remember?"	I asked if he remembered .
Wh-question: keep the question word	"Where did you grow up?"	I asked where she had grown up .

Remove question order She asked **where I lived**, not "where did I live." Reported questions usually end with a period.

Requests and commands

"Please call me." → She asked me **to call** her.

"Don't wait." → He told me **not to wait**.

Useful reporting verbs

Choose a verb that matches the speaker's meaning. Different verbs take different sentence patterns.

admit

Accept that something is true, often unwillingly

He **admitted making** a mistake.

deny

Say something is not true

He **denied taking** the keys.

insist

Say firmly

He **insisted that** he was right.

suggest

Propose an idea

He **suggested taking** the bus.

complain

Say you are unhappy about something

He **complained that** the room was cold.

claim

Say something is true; others may doubt it

She **claimed that** she had called.

explain

Give details or reasons

She **explained that** the bus was late.

mention

Talk about briefly

She **mentioned that** she was moving.

advise

Recommend an action

She **advised me to** arrive early.

promise

Give your word

She **promised to** call.

Use this book when you write

1. **Choose your meaning.** A routine, a finished event, a current activity, or a connection between times?
2. **Find the pattern.** Use the formula chart or the topic page.
3. **Build the sentence.** Check subject, helping verb, and verb form.
4. **Read it again.** Check negatives, question order, and time expressions.

Your most useful pages For sentence building: Build a Sentence (p. 3). For tense patterns: Tense formulas (p. 11). For a model: Worked examples (p. 12). For verb patterns: Verb lists (p. 28).